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Social media and body image in young women: A meta-analysis of experimental studies on video- versus image-based platforms

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ABSTRACT

Social media exposes young women to body-related content that can influence how they perceive their bodies. Given its broad influence, understanding when and how such exposure harms or improves body image is essential for supporting mental health. This meta-analysis synthesized experimental evidence to examine the causal effects of two types of content: body-ideal content promoting beauty standards and body-positive content encouraging acceptance. We also tested whether platform modality (image-based platforms such as Instagram vs. video-based platforms such as TikTok) moderated these effects. The analysis included 20 experimental studies involving 3603 young female participants. Exposure to body-positive content significantly improved body satisfaction (Cohen's $d = 0.20$, $p < .001$), whereas exposure to body-ideal content significantly decreased it (Cohen's $d = -0.29$, $p < .001$). Notably, video-based platforms intensified the negative effect: TikTok body-ideal content produced larger declines ($d = -0.45$) than Instagram image body-ideal content ($d = -0.25$). For body-positive content, effect sizes were similar across platforms ($d = 0.21$ vs. $d = 0.20$), although the number of available studies was limited. These findings provide causal evidence for the effects of social media exposure on body image and highlight platform modality as an important moderator. Body-positive content appears promising for digital interventions to promote body satisfaction, while the particularly harmful impact of body-ideal videos underscores the need to reduce exposure to such content in video-based environments.

1. Introduction

Social media provides pervasive exposure to appearance- and body-related content. A growing body of research has linked social media use to increased body dissatisfaction and disordered eating (de Valle et al., 2021; Holland and Tiggemann, 2016). Platforms like Instagram and TikTok expose users to a continuous stream of curated images and videos, encouraging comparisons with idealized body standards, peer appearances, and societal expectations—often leading to dissatisfaction, anxiety, and reduced self-esteem (Perloff, 2014). Moreover, the dominant body ideals portrayed on social media frequently diverge from the natural diversity of human bodies, reinforcing unrealistic appearance standards and contributing to psychological distress (Holland & Tiggemann, 2016). Given social media's wide reach and influence, body image concerns become increasingly prevalent, representing a growing public health issue with implications for both mental and physical well-being. Therefore, it is essential to understand the mechanisms through which social media shapes body image, informing strategies that prevent dissatisfaction and promote wellbeing.

1.1. Theoretical and empirical background

Several theoretical frameworks provide a foundation for understanding how social media influences body image. Social comparison theory (Festinger, 1954) suggests that individuals evaluate themselves relative to others, and exposure to idealized bodies on social media intensifies upward appearance comparisons. Objectification theory (Fredrickson & Roberts, 1997) further explains how appearance-focused media contributes to self-objectification, leading women in particular to engage in body surveillance and experience body dissatisfaction. The Tripartite Influence Model (Thompson et al., 1999) integrates these perspectives, emphasizing the combined role of media, peers, and family in promoting appearance ideals that are internalized and reinforced through comparison processes. Together, these frameworks predict that exposure to thin-ideal or appearance-focused content on social media will undermine body satisfaction.

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The relationship between social media use and body dissatisfaction is widely studied but remains complex. Early correlational research consistently found positive associations between social media exposure and body image concerns, particularly among women. For example, a meta-analysis of 63 cross-sectional studies identified significant links between appearance-focused social media behaviors (e.g., viewing idealized images, and social comparison) and body dissatisfaction (Saiphoo & Vahedi, 2019). Similarly, Ryding and Kuss (2020) found passive, appearance-oriented social media use was associated with increased body dissatisfaction. These findings align with social comparison and objectification frameworks, which suggest that women are especially vulnerable to the negative effects of appearance-focused content due to heightened tendencies toward comparison and internalized objectification.

Platform-specific investigations have also supported these findings and further revealed that different presentation modalities may be associated with varying impacts on appearance-related outcomes. Recent reviews noted that image-based platforms such as Instagram are more strongly associated with body dissatisfaction than text-based platforms (Harriger et al., 2023; Vandenbosch et al., 2022). Research on video-based platforms is still emerging. For instance, Pan et al. (2023) found that passive TikTok use was associated with lower appearance- and weight-esteem, an effect mediated by state-level social comparison. More directly, Gurtala and Fardouly (2023) found that idealized videos had stronger negative effects on body satisfaction than still images when participants perceived the content as unenhanced or unedited, providing preliminary evidence that immersive video formats may exert stronger negative effects than static images. Collectively, these studies point to the importance of considering presentation modality and highlight the need for further research examining different media formats. Additionally, gender consistently emerges as an essential moderator across platforms. Women engage more frequently in appearance-related activities on various social media platforms and experience greater negative impacts on body esteem than men (Markey et al., 2025).

Recent longitudinal studies suggest that overall social media usage time, in itself, may not reliably predict body dissatisfaction. For instance, a recent daily diary study objectively measured social media usage across multiple platforms (Twitter, Reddit, TikTok, YouTube, Instagram, Facebook) among 252 young adults, finding no significant association between total usage time and body dissatisfaction, even after considering gender, self-esteem, and perfectionistic presentation (Goh et al., 2025). This is consistent with prior research shown that engagement with appearance-focused content, rather than overall time spent on social media, is more directly linked to appearance concerns (e.g., Holland & Tiggemann, 2016).

Emerging research further highlights the importance of content type. Dumas and Desroches (2019) emphasized that body image outcomes depend on specific exposure contexts, such as content characteristics and peer feedback. Further, a diary study found distinct emotional reactions to different Instagram content (e.g., thin ideal, body positivity, fitness, and lifestyle), highlighting the need for content-specific analyses (Glaser et al., 2024).

Experimental evidence provides stronger causal insights by directly manipulating exposure to different content types. A systematic review of 43 experimental studies demonstrated that viewing idealized images consistently increased body dissatisfaction through immediate appearance comparisons (Fioravanti et al., 2022). Content promoting health or fitness ("fitspiration" or "thinspiration") similarly increased dissatisfaction by reinforcing unrealistic body standards (Jeronimo & Carraca, 2022). Conversely, body-positive (BoPo) content, which challenges idealized standards and promotes acceptance of diverse body types, has shown promising yet mixed results. Recent experimental work indicates that exposure to body-positive content can enhance body image outcomes. For example, Nelson et al. (2022) found that body-positive Instagram posts increased body appreciation and satisfaction relative to thin-ideal and neutral content. Additionally, Dhadly et al. (2023) reported improvements in body satisfaction and reductions in negative affect following exposure to body-positive TikTok videos. However, Sanzari et al. (2023) reported minimal effects, while Rodgers et al. (2022) comprehensive review identified generally positive but moderate and variable impacts. Individual differences also critically moderate responses, with women benefiting more from body-positive content but remaining particularly susceptible to the negative effects of thin-ideal imagery (Pritchard & Button, 2024). From a theoretical standpoint, these results indicate that while body-positive content has potential to buffer against the negative processes outlined by comparison and objectification theories, its efficacy may be constrained by various factors, such as the extent to which content remains appearance-focused (Cohen et al., 2019), the heterogeneity of body positive content (Rodgers & Rousseau, 2022), and gender (Pritchard & Button, 2024).

Together, this line of work indicates that both the type of content and the modality of presentation may influence body image outcomes. Such evidence suggests that existing theories of media influence need to be tested across both content and modality dimensions. For example, more immersive formats such as video may potentially amplify comparison and objectification processes relative to static images, although evidence remains limited. Collectively, these findings highlight the complexity of social media's impact on body image and underscore the need for content-specific, modality-specific, and experimentally driven approaches.

1.2. Gaps in theory and empirical evidence

Existing literature examining social media's impact on body image has several notable limitations. First, research examining body-positive content has increased notably in recent years, but these findings have yet to be quantitatively synthesized. Rodgers et al. (2022) reviewed emerging evidence supporting the protective potential of body-positive content on body image, but their summary was qualitative rather than quantitative. Moreover, no meta-analysis to date has directly compared the beneficial effects of body-positive content with the detrimental impacts of body-ideal content, leaving an important research gap regarding the relative magnitude of these effects.

Second, methodological limitations persist across existing reviews. Most prior meta-analyses have predominantly relied upon correlational studies, leaving experimental evidence significantly underrepresented. Furthermore, available experimental syntheses have focused on body-ideal images (de Valle et al., 2021; Fioravanti et al., 2022), with no existing meta-analysis systematically examining the causal impact of body-positive content on body image. As a result, the causal relationship between body-positive content and body image remains unclear.

Third, the role of platform modality remains an open question. It is now well recognized that image-based platforms such as Instagram and Snapchat are more strongly associated with body dissatisfaction than text-based platforms like Twitter and Facebook (Engeln et al., 2020; Karsay et al., 2021). While research on photo-based platforms is well established, studies on video-based platforms such as TikTok are still in early stages (Harriger et al., 2023; Vandenbosch et al., 2022). Preliminary evidence suggests that idealized videos may have stronger negative effects on body image than images when the content is perceived as unenhanced or unedited (Gurtala & Fardouly, 2023). Focusing on video-based media is particularly timely, as social media engagement is rapidly shifting toward short-form video formats such as TikTok and YouTube Shorts. Dynamic and immersive videos may enhance perceived realism and emotional engagement (Sundar, 2008), thereby amplifying the potential impact of social media content. However, no systematic synthesis has yet examined whether this modality effect is consistent across studies.

1.3. The present study and hypotheses

The present meta-analysis addresses these limitations by synthesizing experimental evidence on how social media content exposure influences body satisfaction. Specifically, we distinguish between two types of content: body-ideal content and body-positive content. We also examine platform modality as a moderator, comparing Instagram as a representative image-based platform and TikTok as a representative video-based platform. To enhance the strength of causal inferences, we included only experimental studies in which participants were exposed to either video-based or image-based content.

Given that objectification and sociocultural influence models consistently identify women as especially susceptible to appearance-based comparison and internalization of beauty ideals, we focused on this population. We further targeted young women (including adolescents) because the risk of developing eating disorders rises sharply after puberty and peaks during this period, with approximately 95 % of first-onset cases occurring before age 25 (Dalsgaard et al., 2020; Mangweth-Matzek et al., 2023; Ward et al., 2019). Considering this elevated risk and the role of body-image concerns as a key predictor, examining social media's influence on body image during this period is particularly important for informing early prevention and reducing the risk of persistent or recurrent disorders. Consistent with this focus, most prior research has also targeted young women. To align with prior research and capture the key developmental period, we included studies of women with a mean age between 12 and 35 years. Subgroup analyses were planned to examine developmental differences, provided that a sufficient number of studies were available for each subgroup in the meta-analysis.

Building on empirical evidence and relevant theories (i.e., Social Comparison Theory, Objectification Theory, and the Tripartite Influence Model), we formulated the following main hypotheses:

(1) Exposure to body-ideal content would significantly decrease body satisfaction compared to control conditions.
(2) Exposure to body-positive content would significantly improve body satisfaction compared to control conditions.
(3) The magnitude of both negative (body-ideal) and positive (body-positive) effects may be stronger on video-based platforms (TikTok) than on image-based platforms (Instagram). This hypothesis is tentative, given the limited number of direct empirical studies, but is motivated by research on media modality indicating that dynamic and immersive formats increase perceived realism and emotional engagement.

2. Method

2.1. Pre-registration and deviations

This study was registered on PROSPERO database (ID number: CRD42024554935) prospectively and followed the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses (PRISMA) guidelines (Shamseer et al., 2015). The following deviations occurred after the pre-registration.

Our pre-registered plan was to search studies conducted on three platforms including TikTok, Instagram, and Facebook. However, after the screening phase, only one study based on Facebook was found to meet our inclusion criteria. In addition, Facebook as a platform has distinctive features that focus on a mixture of text- and image-based content. Thus, given this limited representation and the platform's distinct functional characteristics, we excluded Facebook to prioritize focused comparisons between TikTok (video-based) and Instagram (image-based).

During the coding phase, we noticed a critical distinction in social media contents and their body image impact, namely, body-positive content, which promotes acceptance of diverse body types and challenges narrow beauty standards, and body-ideal content, which emphasizes idealized body images that often align with culturally or socially dominant appearance norms. This polarity necessitated content categorization rather than aggregated analysis. Thus, we implemented separate effect size estimations for body-positive and body-ideal content.

Finally, although our pre-registered plan included studies on young women aged 12–35 and planned subgroup analyses to examine potential developmental differences, no adolescent samples met inclusion criteria. Consequently, the final analyzed age range was 18–35 years.

2.2. Search strategy

The literature search was started in June 2024, covering databases including Web of Science, Scopus, PubMed, EBSCO, and PsycArticles. A cross-search strategy was employed, utilizing keywords and Boolean operators to identify relevant concepts across social media platforms and various dimensions of body image. To capture social media use, the following search terms were used: TikTok, douyin, short video, and Instagram. Search terms used to capture the components of body image were: body image, body esteem, physical appearance, body dissatisfaction, satisfaction, weight, and beauty. In addition, we also identified relevant articles from review papers in this research field. The publication time frame was restricted to 2017–June 2024, based on the release date of TikTok. A secondary search was conducted in February 2025 to capture any additional publications. A third search was conducted in August 2025 during revision.

The literature screening process adhered strictly to the PRISMA guidelines (Shamseer et al., 2015; see Fig. 1). Initially, relevance was assessed based on titles to include articles related to the study of social media and body image. Then, selection criteria were applied to the abstract and finally to the full text to get all the studies suitable for the current meta-analysis. A comprehensive description of the inclusion criteria is provided in the following section.

2.3. Inclusion criteria

To be included in the analysis, studies must meet the following inclusion criteria:

(1) Experimental research based on original data: Only experimental studies based on original data were included. Non-experimental research (e.g., cross-sectional studies, retrospective analyses, case reports, theoretical models, literature reviews, and observational longitudinal studies) were excluded. The experimental design must meet the basic requirements for causal inference, with at least one group exposed to body-positive or body-ideal related content, and one control condition exposed to content not related to body.
(2) Sample characteristics: The study sample must consist of the general population of adolescent and young adult females aged 12–35. Studies that involved professional social media workers (e.g., digital marketers) and special populations (e.g., clinical samples, individuals with intellectual disabilities, severe physical disabilities, athletes) were excluded. This is because the effects of body image and social media use may differ in these populations, making them unrepresentative of the general population. Studies that did not specify gender composition were excluded, while those specifying male and female demographics with segregated data presentation were included for analysis.
(3) Social media platforms: Eligible studies had to focus on exposure to content from a specific social media platform and report outcome data separately for each platform when comparisons were made. We excluded studies that examined isolated platform features (e.g., appearance vs. reality manipulations, disclaimer labels, captions, likes, shares, or recommendation algorithms)

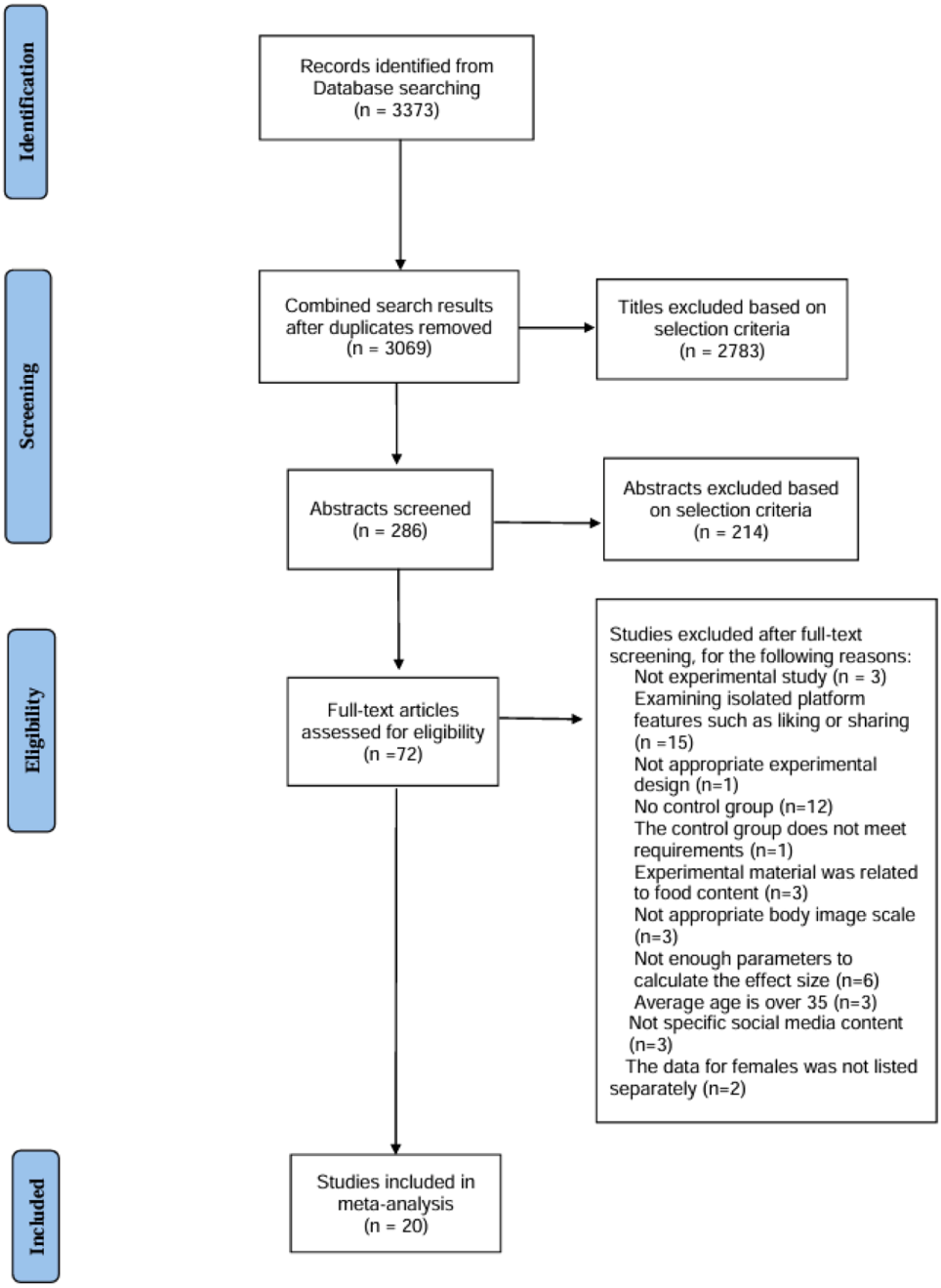

Fig. 1. Search strategy according to the PRISMA guideline.

rather than overall content exposure. This exclusion was applied because feature-specific manipulations test interface design elements or user cues rather than the broader effects of exposure to body-ideal or body-positive content. Including such studies would have limited comparability across platforms and shifted the focus away from our primary aim of evaluating general platform-level effects, particularly the contrast between image-based (Instagram) and video-based (TikTok) modalities.

(4) Measurement of body image: Body image must be measured using self-report scales that capture emotional and cognitive dimensions (e.g., body satisfaction, appearance anxiety, body shape identity). The study should clearly indicate whether it was measuring body satisfaction or other dimensions of body image (e.g., body shame, body anxiety).

(5) Publication requirements: Only formally published, peer-reviewed journal articles were included. Theses, conference abstracts, news reports, non-peer-reviewed publications, and other non-academic or informal sources will be excluded.

(6) Language restriction: This study only included English-language publications.

(7) Effect size calculation: Studies must report the statistical data necessary to calculate the effect size. Authors were contacted for studies without necessary data.

2.4. Coding

2.4.1. Sample characteristics

(1) Age: Mean age and age ranges were coded.

(2) Female Ratio: To focus on female participants, the proportion of female participants in each study was documented.
(3) Body Mass Index (BMI): If available, mean BMI or BMI ranges were recorded as an indicator of physical status.
(4) Ethnic Composition: Ethnic distributions within samples were coded, including proportional representation of major ethnic groups (e.g., Caucasian, African American, and Asian).
(5) Sample Size: Total participant numbers were extracted, with subgroup sizes (e.g., experimental vs. control groups) explicitly recorded.

2.4.2. Study characteristics

(1) Geographic Context: Study location (country/region) was documented.
(2) Social Media Platform: Platform names were recorded (e.g., Instagram, TikTok). Comparative studies examining multiple platforms (e.g., Gurtala & Fardouly, 2023) were coded separately for individual platforms.
(3) Body Image Measurement: Self-report scales were categorized into: a) VAS: Visual Analogue Scale; b) BISS: The Body Image

Table 1
Descriptions and characteristics of studies included in the meta-analysis.

Study	Geographic location	Sample size (Exp/Control)	average age	platform	content type	Measure of body image	experimental group	control group
Anixiadis et al. (2019)	Australia	63/63	23.28 ± 2.58	Instagram	bodyideal	VAS	thin-ideal	scenery
Barnes et al.(2023)	UK	195/189	23.51 ± 3.31	Instagram	bodyideal	VAS	fit ideal	home décor
Barron et al.(2021)	USA	65/64	19.12 ± 1.81	Instagram	bodyideal	VAS	fitspiration	architecture
Cohen et al. (2019) -result1	Australia	65/65	21.69 ± 3.49	Instagram	bodypositive	VAS	body positive	nature
Cohen et al. (2019) -result2	Australia	65/65	21.69 ± 3.49	Instagram	bodyideal	VAS	thin-ideal	nature
Dhadly et al. (2023) -result1	Canada	54/48	18.44 ± 1.07	TikTok	bodypositive	BISS	body positive	neutral
Dhadly et al. (2023)-result2	Canada	54/48	18.44 ± 1.07	TikTok	bodyideal	BISS	body focused	neutral
Fiuza & Rodgers (2023)	USA	130/134	19.49 ± 1.1	TikTok	bodypositive	VAS	#bodypositivity,#body positive, #self-love	animal
Gurtala & Fardouly (2023)-result1	Australia	54/53	19.19 ± 1.80	Instagram	bodyideal	VAS	appearance-ideal	aesthetic house tours
Gurtala & Fardouly (2023)-result2	Australia	52/52	19.19 ± 1.80	TikTok	bodyideal	VAS	appearance-ideal	aesthetic living rooms
Karsay et al.(2025)	Austria	75/71	22.4 ± 3.64	Instagram	bodyideal	BISS	fitspiration	scenery
Ladwig et al. (2024) -result1	Germany	53/81	29.16 ± 7.4	Instagram	bodyideal	BISS	fitspiration	text-based “body neutrality”
Ladwig et al. (2024) -result2	Germany	76/81	29.16 ± 7.4	Instagram	bodypositive	BISS	body positive	text-based “body neutrality”
Manning and Mulgrew (2022)	Australia	77/78	22.50 ± 3.52	Instagram	bodypositive	VAS	body diversity	cityscape
McComb and Mills (2022) -result1	Canada	102/101	19.53 ± 1.74	Instagram	bodyideal	BISS	fit-ideal	home décor and furniture
McComb and Mills (2022) -result2	Canada	99/101	19.53 ± 1.74	Instagram	bodyideal	BISS	thin	home décor and furniture
McComb and Mills (2022) -result3	Canada	100/101	19.53 ± 1.74	Instagram	bodyideal	BISS	slim-thin	home décor and furniture
Nerini et al. (2024)	Italy	35/35	24.30 ± 3.47	Instagram	bodyideal	BSQ	thin ideal	neutral
Prichard et al. (2020)	Australia	53/55	20.24 ± 1.86	Instagram	bodyideal	VAS	fitspiration	travel
Prichard et al. (2023) -Study1	Australia	74/74	20.46 ± 2.31	Instagram	bodyideal	VAS	sexualized	fashion products
Prichard et al. (2023) -Study2	Australia	72/74	20.46 ± 2.31	Instagram	bodyideal	VAS	fashion	fashion products
Pryde & Prichard (2022)	Australia	61/59	21.06 ± 2.40	TikTok	bodyideal	VAS	fitspiration	art
Rounds & Stutts (2021)	USA	92/93	20.17 ± 1.25	Instagram	bodyideal	BISS	fitspiration	travel
Seekis & Kennedy (2023) -result 1	Australia	39/38	19.37 ± 1.89	TikTok	bodyideal	PASTAS	beauty	travel
Seekis & Kennedy (2023) -result 2	Australia	38/38	19.37 ± 1.89	TikTok	bodypositive	PASTAS	self -compassion	travel
Seekis & Lawrence (2023) -result1	Australia	63/63	19.25 ± 1.98	TikTok	bodyideal	VAS	thin ideal	art
Seekis & Lawrence (2023) -result2	Australia	63/63	19.25 ± 1.98	TikTok	bodypositive	VAS	body neutrality	art
Slater et al. (2019)	UK	48/54	23.55 ± 2.33	Instagram	bodyideal	VAS	thin-ideal	humorous parody
Sullivan et al.(2024)	USA	56/60	18.77 ± 1.05	Instagram	bodypositive	VAS	Body positive	architectural

Note. VAS: Visual Analogue Scale; BISS: The Body Image States Scale; BSQ: the Body Shape Questionnaire-14; PASTAS: The Physical Appearance State and Trait Anxiety Scale

States Scale; c) BSQ: the Body Shape Questionnaire-14; d) PASTAS: The Physical Appearance State and Trait Anxiety Scale.

(4) Experimental Design: Key methodological features were cataloged, including control group parameters, stimulus presentation protocols, and randomization procedures.
(5) Content Type: Social media content was classified as "Body Positive" (BoPo, content emphasizing body diversity and self-acceptance) or "Body Ideal" (content reinforcing sociocultural appearance standards).
(6) Publication Year: The year of publication was recorded.
(7) Core Findings: Study conclusions were synthesized to identify directional effects (positive/negative/null), moderating variables, and population-specific outcomes, forming the basis for meta-analytic synthesis.

2.5. Data extraction

Data extraction was independently performed by two authors (ZY and XSH), and the extracted effect sizes were organized into a table for meta-analysis. For experimental studies, the data table contains the following information: the average age of participants, age range, the valid sample size, the proportion of female participants, the country where the study was conducted, the sample type, and the measurement tools used in the study. If the study involved male participants, data for the female participants were extracted separately (in most studies, effect sizes for male and female participants were reported separately, allowing them to be treated as independent samples).

The data table records the data information (mean ± standard deviation) for both the experimental and control groups. For studies that did not report means and standard deviations but provided F or t-values for the experimental and control groups, these F or t-values were recorded for calculating effect sizes. A description of each study included in the analysis is presented in Table 1.

2.6. Statistical analyses

2.6.1. Calculation of effect sizes

This study used the effect size calculator website (https://campbellcollaboration.org/research-resources/effect-size-calculator.html) to calculate the effect size between experimental and control groups. Based on the characteristics of the experimental design, the sample size, mean (or adjusted mean), and standard deviation (or standard error) for both the experimental and control groups were inputted. For studies with only post-test data, effect sizes were calculated from the means and standard deviations of the experimental and control groups at post-test. For studies reporting both pre- and post-test data, effect sizes were calculated using a difference-in-differences approach, which adjusts Cohen's *d* for baseline differences based on pretest and post-test means and standard deviations. The final output included Cohen's d value, sampling variance, and 95 % confidence intervals. Since all studies included in this research had large sample sizes ($n \geq 50$), the difference between Cohen's d and Hedge's g was negligible. Therefore, Cohen's d was used as the final effect size measure in this study. Given that some studies used body satisfaction as a measurement indicator, while others used body dissatisfaction or body anxiety (Anixiadis et al., 2019; Ladwig et al., 2024; Nerini et al., 2024; Prichard et al., 2020; Prichard et al., 2023; Pryde & Prichard, 2022), to ensure consistency in the direction of effect sizes (standardized as "positive improvement"), the effect sizes measuring body dissatisfaction or body shame were symbolically reversed to align the results.

2.6.2. Meta-analyses

Meta-analysis was conducted using the statistical analysis software R (version 4.3.1). Data analysis was performed using the metafor package (version 4.8.0), which was also used for producing the forest plots and funnel plots (Viechtbauer, 2010). The summary effect size was calculated using a random-effects model.

2.6.3. Moderator analyses

To investigate potential sources of variability in effect sizes, moderator analyses were performed when significant heterogeneity was detected. The primary analysis examined the moderating role of content type, contrasting body positivity content with body ideal content in their associations with body image. Secondary analyses evaluated platform architecture as a moderator by stratifying effects into image-based (Instagram) and video-oriented (TikTok) categories. All analyses adhered to the methodological framework proposed by Lortie, utilizing the metafor package for model specification (Lortie, 2022; Viechtbauer, 2010). Restricted maximum likelihood (REML) estimation generated mixed-effects models with 95 % confidence intervals, explicitly quantifying between-study variance components.

2.6.4. Testing heterogeneity

Between-study heterogeneity was statistically evaluated using Q statistic, computed through weighted residual sum-of-squares calculations within the metafor package. A statistically significant Q value ($p < .05$) indicated substantial variability beyond random sampling error (Laird et al., 2017).

2.6.5. Publication bias

Given that publication bias (i.e., the tendency for studies with statistically significant results to be more likely published) may lead to a positive bias in the aggregated effect size due to the over-representation of significant results in the literature, Egger's regression intercept (Egger et al., 1997) was used to test for evidence of publication bias. A significant result suggests the potential presence of publication bias.

2.6.6. Risk of bias

To evaluate the methodological quality of the included experimental studies, we conducted a risk of bias assessment using the Cochrane Risk of Bias tool (RoB 2.0) (Sterne et al., 2019). Each study was independently assessed across key domains, including the randomization process, deviations from intended interventions, missing outcome data, measurement of the outcome, and selection of the reported result. Studies were categorized as having low risk, some concerns, or high risk of bias based on Cochrane guidelines.

3. Results

3.1. Risk of bias assessment

Risk of bias assessments for the 20 included experimental studies is summarized in Fig. 2. Overall, no study was rated as "high risk" of bias in any domain. In the domain assessing the randomization process, 5 studies (25.0 %) were rated as having "some concerns," primarily due to insufficient information regarding whether the allocation sequence was concealed prior to participant enrollment and assignment. For the domain concerning deviations from intended interventions, 5 studies (25.0 %) were rated as having "some concerns," most often because it was unclear whether participants were aware of their assigned intervention. In the domain assessing missing outcome data, 19 studies (95.0 %) were rated as "low risk," whereas 1 study (5.0 %) was rated as having "some concerns" due to unclear reporting on whether all randomized participants were accounted for in the analysis. For bias related to the measurement of the outcome and the selection of the reported results, all studies were rated as "low risk."

Regarding the overall risk of bias ratings, 8 studies (40.0 %) were categorized as having "some concerns," reflecting issues identified in the randomization process, deviations from intended interventions, or missing outcome data, while being rated as "low risk" in all other domains. The remaining 12 studies (60.0 %) were rated as "low risk" across all domains.

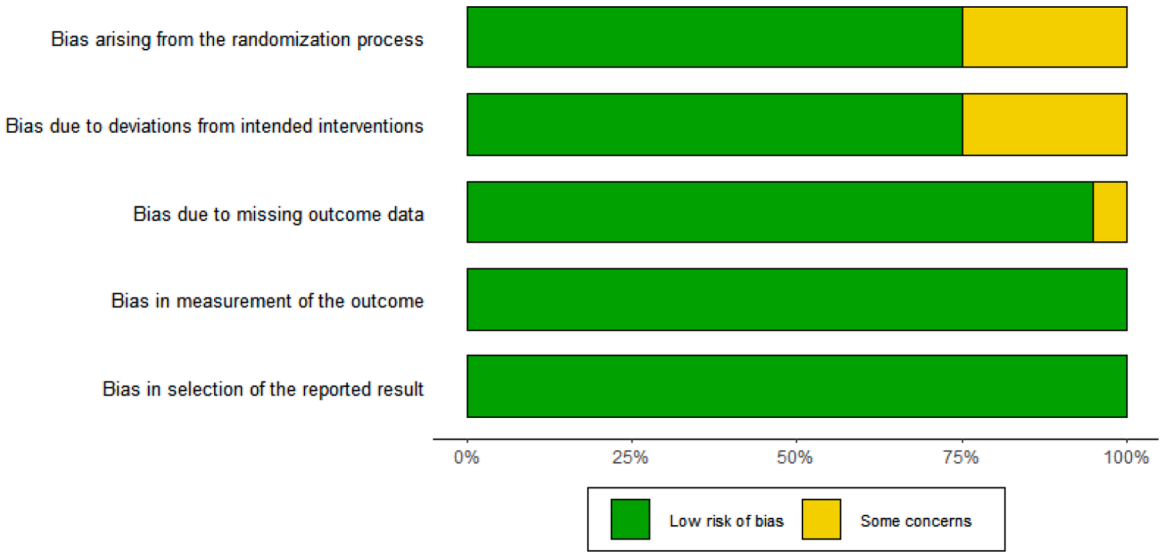

Fig. 2. Risk of bias assessment results.

3.2. Meta-analyses

The present meta-analysis synthesized experimental results examining the effects of social media content exposure on body satisfaction among young women. Based on 20 studies ($N = 3603$), a total of 29 effect sizes (Cohen's *d*) were calculated. Overall, a Q value of 69.06 ($p < .0001$) was obtained, indicating significant heterogeneity across the included studies.

We distinguished two types of social media content: body-positive content, emphasizing body diversity and self-acceptance, and body-ideal content, reinforcing sociocultural appearance standards. A positive d value indicates that, compared to control content, social media exposure had a positive impact on body satisfaction, while a negative d value indicates a negative impact. As shown in Fig. 3, body-positive content induced a positive effect on body satisfaction, with effect sizes ranging from 0.13 (Seekis & Kennedy, 2023) to 0.36 (Seekis & Lawrence, 2023), and a pooled effect size of 0.20 (95 % CI = [0.085, 0.32]). In contrast, body-ideal content induced a negative effect on body satisfaction, with effect sizes ranging from –0.98 (Seekis & Kennedy, 2023) to –0.06 (Barron et al., 2021), and a pooled effect size of –0.29 (95 % CI = [–0.36, –0.22]).

Subsequently, we examined whether the absolute magnitude of effect sizes differed between body-ideal and body-positive content. Because body-ideal content was associated with negative effects and body-positive content with positive effects, all effect sizes were converted to absolute values before moderation analysis. The analysis

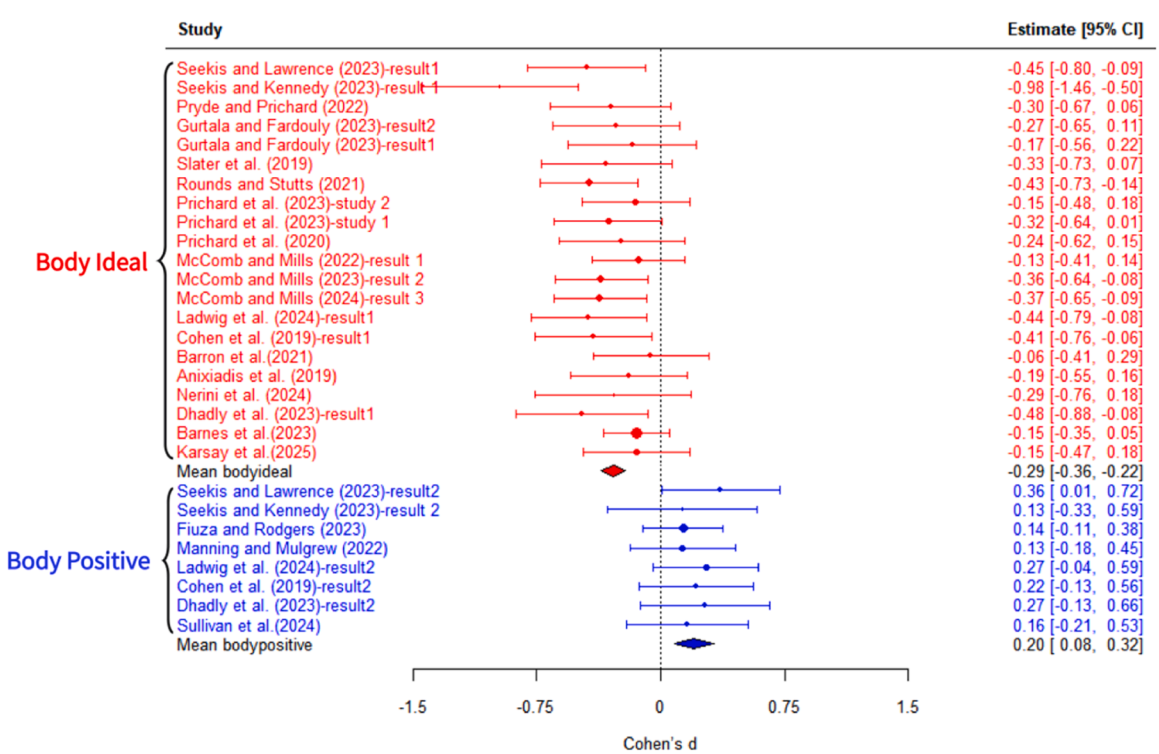

Fig. 3. Effect sizes of studies included in the current meta-analysis. The studies were categorized by their social media content into "body-ideal" and "body-positive" groups.

showed no significant moderation by content type ($QM(1) = 1.46$, $p = .23$). Despite a slightly higher mean absolute effect size for body-ideal content ($|d| = 0.29$) compared to body-positive content ($|d| = 0.20$), this difference was not statistically significant.

Next, we examined whether platform modality moderated the effects of social media content on body satisfaction. Given the opposite directions of effects for body-ideal and body-positive content, analyses were conducted separately for each content type.

For body-positive content exposures, platform modality (image- vs. video-based) was not a significant moderator ($QM(1) = 0.011$, $p = .92$; see Table 2). Video-based content ($d = 0.21$, $SE = 0.085$, 95 % CI = [0.043, 0.38]) produced effects comparable to image-based content ($d = 0.20$, $SE = 0.086$, 95 % CI = [0.029, 0.36]).

For body-ideal content, modality significantly moderated outcomes ($QM(1) = 4.19$, $p = .041$; see Table 2). Video-based content showed a stronger negative influence on body satisfaction ($d = -0.45$, $SE = 0.089$, 95 % CI = [–0.63 –0.28]) than image-based content ($d = -0.25$, $SE = 0.040$, 95 % CI = [–0.33, –0.17]). These findings indicate that dynamic video depictions of idealized bodies may have especially detrimental effects on young women's body satisfaction.

3.3. Publication bias

Finally, we assessed potential publication bias. To enable a unified analysis across all studies, effect sizes from body-ideal exposures (which were negative by definition) were re-coded to positive values, so that larger values consistently reflected a stronger impact on body satisfaction regardless of direction. Egger's test was not significant ($z = 1.83$, $p = .067$), providing no significant evidence of publication bias (Fig. 4).

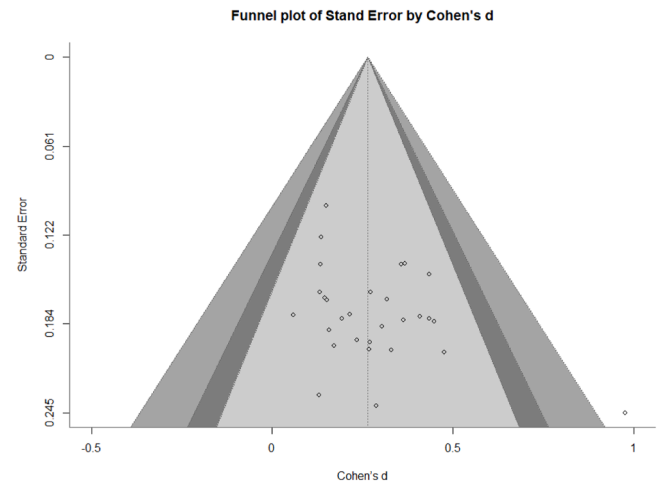

Fig. 4. Publication bias assessment using a funnel plot. Filled circles represent individual studies, with effect sizes (Cohen's *d*) plotted against their standard errors.

4. Discussion

The present meta-analysis synthesized experimental evidence on the effects of social media content exposure on body satisfaction among young adult women. Across 20 studies, we consistently found that exposure to body-ideal content significantly reduced body satisfaction, while exposure to body-positive content significantly enhanced body satisfaction compared to control conditions. Furthermore, platform modality moderated the negative impact of body-ideal content, with stronger declines observed on video-based platforms (TikTok) than on image-based platforms (Instagram). For body-positive content, effects appeared similar across platforms, although the evidence is limited, with only four studies available for each. Taken together, these findings provide causal evidence for the influence of social media exposure on body image and highlight the importance of considering both content type and platform modality in future research and intervention design.

4.1. The role of platform modality: video-based versus image-based media

Past research has contrasted the effects of image-based versus text-based content on body image, with growing consensus that image-centric platforms such as Instagram are more detrimental to body satisfaction than text-heavy platforms like Facebook or Twitter (Engeln et al., 2020; Karsay et al., 2021; Vandenbosch et al., 2022). Building on this foundation, the present meta-analysis extended platform comparisons by synthesizing recent experimental studies conducted on TikTok, which is a rapidly growing, video-based platform especially popular among adolescents and young adults. Our findings indicate that video-based platforms amplify the negative impact of body-ideal content relative to image-based platforms. For body-positive content, however, effects did not differ significantly across platforms. Given the very limited number of studies available, it is unclear whether this reflects a genuine absence of modality effects or simply insufficient evidence at this stage. These results suggest that platform modality may play an active role in shaping responses to social media content, but further experimental research is needed, particularly for body-positive exposure.

One possible explanation for the heightened impact of body-ideal videos lies in the psychological experience of immersion. TikTok's design encourages continuous engagement and may foster flow experiences, in which users become deeply absorbed and lose track of time. Drawing on Uses and Gratifications Theory, Roberts and David (2023) found that TikTok users reported significantly stronger flow states than Instagram users. Notably, one subdimension of flow—telepresence, the sensation of being "transported" into a media environment—was associated with elevated depression and anxiety, suggesting that immersive platforms may amplify both the emotional resonance and psychological cost of appearance-focused content. Although TikTok is not immersive in the technical sense of virtual reality—which has been widely explored for psychological intervention (Persky & Lewis, 2019)—it shares key experiential features such as sensory richness and perceived realism. These characteristics may help explain why video-based content exerts a more powerful influence on body image than static imagery.

Table 2
Effect of platform modality with body-positive and body-ideal content.

Conditions	No. studies	No. effect sizes	Mean effect size	z-value
Body Positive				
Image-based	4	4	0.196	2.294*
Video-based	4	4	0.209	2.464*
Body Ideal				
Image-based	13	16	−0.254	−6.289***
Video-based	5	5	−0.454	−5.097***

* $p < 0.05$, *** $p <. 001$

4.2. The impacts of body-ideal and body-positive content

A central contribution of this meta-analysis is that it provides a quantitative synthesis of experimental studies on body-positive content. Across available studies, exposure to body-positive material consistently improved body satisfaction, supporting the protective potential suggested by prior qualitative reviews (Rodgers et al., 2022; Vandenbosch et al., 2022). At the same time, exposure to body-ideal content reliably decreased body satisfaction, confirming the robust harmful effects documented in earlier syntheses (de Valle et al., 2021; Fioravanti et al., 2022). We also examined whether the magnitude of these effects differed. Although body-ideal exposure showed a descriptively larger mean effect ($|d| = 0.29$) than body-positive exposure ($|d| = 0.20$), this difference was not statistically significant. Given the limited number of studies and variability in design, current evidence does not allow firm

conclusions about whether harmful effects reliably outweigh protective benefits. Future research with larger and more balanced samples is needed to clarify the relative strength of these pathways.

The beneficial effects of body-positive content can be understood through several theoretical lenses. Body-positive messaging challenges traditional beauty norms by emphasizing body diversity and self-acceptance, thereby disrupting the internalization pathway described in sociocultural models of body dissatisfaction (Thompson et al., 1999). From this perspective, exposure to diverse and affirming portrayals may counteract the harmful comparisons elicited by idealized imagery and promote more adaptive standards of evaluation. However, objectification theory (Fredrickson & Roberts, 1997) highlights a potential limitation: because body-positive posts often retain a focus on physical appearance, they may inadvertently reinforce self-objectification. Cohen et al. (2019), for instance, found that body-positive Instagram posts improved body satisfaction, appreciation, and mood, but also increased self-objectification relative to appearance-neutral content. Thus, body-positive content appears capable of improving body satisfaction by promoting acceptance and diversity, yet its effectiveness may be constrained when messages remain heavily appearance-oriented.

4.3. Limitations and outlook

Several limitations of the present meta-analysis should be acknowledged.

First, our moderator analyses were largely based on comparisons across studies rather than within studies, with the exception of a few studies that directly manipulated platform or content conditions (Cohen et al.,2019; Dhadly et al., 2023; Gurtala & Fardouly, 2023; Ladwig et al., 2024). Although between-study comparisons allow for broader generalization, they also introduce potential confounding factors, as studies may differ in aspects beyond platform modality or content type. For example, the TikTok studies typically sampled younger participants (around 18–19 years), whereas Instagram studies included somewhat older samples (Table 1). Thus, age and platform are partly confounded in the available data, which complicates interpretation of platform effects. Future experiments could compare platform or content effects within the same sample to minimize confounding and enhance comparability.

Second, there was notable variability in how body-positive content was defined across studies—some focused on plus-size models (Ladwig et al., 2024), while others emphasized body diversity (Manning and Mulgrew, 2022) or general self-acceptance (Seekis & Lawrence, 2023). This inconsistency may contribute to heterogeneity in observed effects and underscores the need for more theoretically grounded and consistent operationalization in future research.

Third, the nature of control conditions varied across studies, including neutral content (e.g., Dhadly et al., 2023), non-appearance-related social media posts (Ladwig et al., 2024; Slater et al., 2019), nature images (e.g., Cohen et al., 2019; Fiuza & Rodgers, 2023), aesthetic conditions (e.g., Pryde & Prichard, 2022; Gurtala & Fardouly, 2023), and travel destinations (Prichard et al., 2020; Rounds & Stutts, 2021). These differences may influence the magnitude of observed effects, as certain control stimuli, such as calming nature scenes, may themselves affect mood or body-related outcomes, potentially inflating or deflating the estimated effects of experimental content.

Fourth, all included studies examined only short-term effects following a single exposure, limiting our understanding of how body-ideal and body-positive content affect individuals over time. Future research should employ longitudinal experimental designs that examine both the short- and long-term effects of single and repeated exposures to body-ideal and body-positive content, allowing for a comprehensive understanding of their cumulative and lasting impact on body image and well-being.

Fifth, although we selected TikTok as a representative video-based platform and Instagram as a representative image-based platform, Instagram is no longer purely image-based and now incorporates substantial video content. This evolution reduces the contrast between the two platforms and should be considered in future research.

Finally, to further enhance ecological validity, future research should account for the role of content recommendation algorithms. Platforms like TikTok and Instagram curate content through algorithmic systems. These algorithms may amplify particular types of content based on user engagement patterns, influencing exposure in ways that interact with both content valence and platform features. Investigating these dynamics will be essential for developing more realistic models of social media influence on body image.

5. Conclusion

This meta-analysis synthesized experimental evidence to provide causal insights into how social media content exposure influences body satisfaction among young adult women. By focusing exclusively on experimental studies, the present work advances the field beyond previous correlational findings, offering stronger support for directional effects. Our results underscore the critical importance of content type: while body-positive content can improve body satisfaction, body-ideal content exerts consistently harmful effects. Platform modality also emerged as relevant, with video-based platforms amplifying the negative effects of body-ideal content. However, the difference between video- and image-based formats was not significant for body-positive content.

These findings have practical implications for interventions. Programs aiming to promote healthier body image may leverage body-positive content across both video- and image-based platforms, as both formats show potential to improve body satisfaction. Future research could directly compare delivery formats of body-positive content within the same sample to test whether modality moderates intervention effectiveness, and could also explore how evolving platform features influence outcomes. At the same time, given the stronger harmful effects of body-ideal content on video-based platforms, interventions may benefit from prioritizing efforts to reduce exposure to such material in short-form video environments or examining features that could attenuate its negative impact.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Yu Zhang: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Sihan Xiong:** Investigation, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Nisha Yao:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Supervision, Methodology, Investigation, Conceptualization. **Jing Chen:** Writing – review & editing, Validation, Supervision, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Conceptualization.

Declaration of Generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the writing process

During the preparation of this work the authors used ChatGPT (OpenAI, https://openai.com/) in order to enhance the readability and language of this article. After using this tool, the authors reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the published article.

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Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no competing interests.

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Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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